

Trainee Pilots *Pant Nagar, Uttarakhand*

Life Takes Wing

Pant Nagar, a small town in Uttarakhand's Himalayan foothills named after its eponymous university, is the unlikely place for dreams to take wing. But in the town's other big draw, a 3-km-long cement strip which houses Amber Aviation Flying School, a dozen trainee pilots take turns buzzing around like dragonflies in shiny white Cessna 172s. They are notching up the 200 precious hours that will give them the Commercial Pilot's Licence (CPL), the first step towards becoming a pilot of a commercial airliner. "Money, glamour and a passion for flying," the dozen youth just out of college from middle-class families in Punjab, Haryana and Delhi are near unanimous about why they are here.

Gyandeep Kaur, 19, the daughter of a machinery manufacturer from Delhi, is living out her mother's unrealised dream of becoming a pilot. "That was my biggest motivation," she says. "All my classmates wanted to be doctors or engineers, but I wanted to do something different," says Rasleen Brar, 18, whose parents run a private school in Faridkot. But with a majority having taken hefty loans towards paying the Rs 20-lakh course fee, it's not hard to guess what the prime motivator is. Then there is the double jeopardy of this not being the best time to be an airline pilot and recover their investment in time. The aviation industry is in deep recession and already hundreds of qualified commercial pilots are jobless. Yet

neither this gloomy scenario, nor the prospect of competing against each other, has scared this determined lot. Vijit Verma, 23, an Air Force officer's son from Dehradun, vows to pursue flying because the prospect of sitting at home after his CPL is "unthinkable". Ergo, each has a Plan B, whether it is a bank job or one in a call centre. Or like Gurusevak Singh Toor, 20, son of a senior IPS officer, who will take a shot at the civil services if he can't become a pilot. The batch has a disdain for corruption and chafe at the use of influence but, strangely, says they wouldn't hesitate to pull strings to get ahead. Success at any cost is fine, especially when the costs are so high.

by Sandeep Unnithan

BRAR (FRONT LEFT) WITH
HER BATCHMATES



"Being a pilot means you're responsible for 200 passengers' safety. What could be more empowering than that?"

RASLEEN BRAR Student, Amber Aviation Flying School